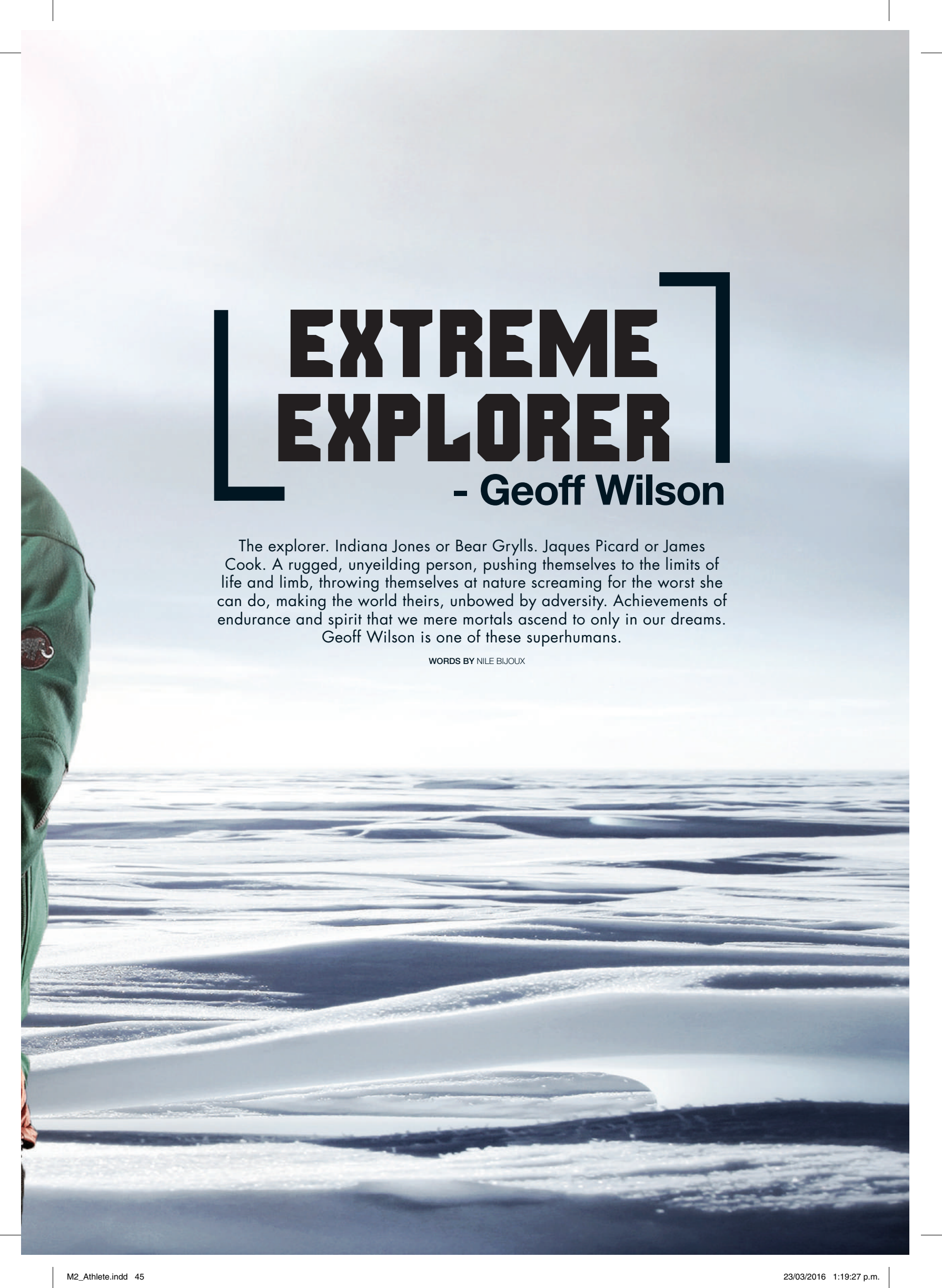




A person wearing a green jacket is visible on the left side of the frame, looking out over a vast, flat, icy landscape. The landscape is covered in a layer of snow or ice, with some darker patches visible. The sky is bright and clear, with a slight gradient from light blue to white. The overall scene is one of a remote, cold environment.

EXTREME EXPLORER

- Geoff Wilson

The explorer. Indiana Jones or Bear Grylls. Jaques Picard or James Cook. A rugged, unyielding person, pushing themselves to the limits of life and limb, throwing themselves at nature screaming for the worst she can do, making the world theirs, unbowed by adversity. Achievements of endurance and spirit that we mere mortals ascend to only in our dreams.

Geoff Wilson is one of these superhumans.

WORDS BY NILE BIJOUX

Right from a tender age, Geoff had the bug to explore. Born in Kenya but growing up in Uganda until he was 5, his first adventure was escaping the dictator Idi Amin with his family in a tiny Cessna 175 Skylark. He stood up to charging elephants when he was 12, had a machine gun held to his head at 18 and has evaded pirates - twice. With notable world records ranging from the longest land journey by kite of the Sahara, to kiteboarding from Australia to Papua New Guinea, to the fastest solo unsupported crossing of Antarctica in history – he draws on incredible experiences to create insights for us in our business and personal lives that can once again create clarity and purpose where previously we felt stuck. He runs the business 5th Element Expeditions, who regularly organise challenging trips with the goal of giving people the skills needed to survive in harsh environments that can also readily convert into tackling business-related stresses and issues. Naturally he has a rather busy life, but recently we caught up with him for a quick chat.

- I was reading up on you Geoff, your life sounds like a movie! To kick things off, I was just wondering – how intense is it out there, alone in the wilderness?

Well, it varies from person to person really. I was training in the Canadian Arctic and my trainer said she had no concern for my ability. She said she was more worried about the isolation. Humans aren't meant to be alone for that long, y'know. We're essentially pack animals. Ninety days of isolation – that's torture. That's what they use in prisons and stuff to get people to crack. It's very very hard, which is why there are so few solo journeys. Especially in Antarctica – there's no colour, no taste, no smell.

- So how would you relate this psychological battle to starting a business?

Well we have our own adventure business so I can form a direct relationship. It's a different stress but you can take what you learn out there and bring it back to the business point of view. Our business is designed to reinvigorate people, on a personal and corporate level. It's a repurposing of energy. When you're on the Antarctic continent and you're in the face of those dangers, you have a moment where you say to yourself "I can do this, I can push through this. I can find new reserves of energy and purpose I never had before." So it's a really powerful tool, using the lessons of the wild in the business sense. I'd call it an unfair advantage in a hostile environment. And that's not a sales pitch, it's just what it is.

- Yeah, there's a lot of psychological pitfalls and dedication you need to get around these when you're starting your own business. A lot of that would come from being so alone for such a long period of time right?

Oh yeah. There's basically nothing I use in the Sahara, or Antarctica that I don't use in business. We don't grow our business to crazy heights because I'm in the field so much but there will come a time when I am out there less and I can use the skills I've learnt more. At the time being, it's about having key conversations with corporate and passing along as much of those skills in a very short amount of time.

- Have you got any tips for starting businesses or people missing the inspiration they once had and need a boost?

Yeah sure. I have a presentation here where I outline what I believe translates the best. It starts with what I've experienced – so things like working in Aceh among 200,000 dead after the 2004 Boxing Day tsunami, getting chased by pirates by sailboat, near death on a reef in Indonesia, first and only wind-assisted crossing of the Sahara desert and kite-surfing the Torres Strait between Australia and Papua New Guinea... Simpson desert crossing, Namibian desert crossing and Antarctica. So based on this, I narrowed my experiences down to a few main learnings. Number one, expect hostility and prepare well for them. Don't be naïve. And most of all, know that we build character in the valleys of our life.



- I like that, it's a good thing to remember.

(Laughs) yeah, it's good eh? The next one there is to adopt the philosophy of having an 'all in or not at all' approach. With that mental attitude, you are already prepared. Ready to go. The obstacle that stops one man or woman strengthens another resolve to push through. The difference is the mental approach is agreed upon at the outset of the journey so you're already protected from giving up, basically. Usually I'd go in depth here, but for sake of time I won't.

The third thing is to never, ever give up. Don't enter with an exit strategy; don't have a plan to fail. Stand by Ernest Shackleton's family motto: "By endurance, we conquer." So the most important part of the third set is to continually move your feet. Don't expect different results from the same input. If something is not creating breakthroughs in your business or your personal life, then change tack. Do something different until you do breakthrough or you do prevail. The fourth step is to reassess, revise and repeat. Don't ever stagnate. Once you have achieved your goal, go back to the dream phase, write it down and make a new plan.

- So basically, constantly have something you're aiming for?

Yeah, so you're not ever just going "oh cool I did it, I'm out of here now." For driven and business people, the most dangerous part of business is often achieving the goal they set, and then sitting down and stopping.

- Ah okay, so it's sort of like constantly setting yourself new goals? So you always have something to strive for?

Yeah, but definitely congratulate yourself. Take a break for sure, but remember to reset that benchmark and you're driving forwards, so you don't end up at a point where you go "oh jeez, what am I doing with my life... I'm kinda lost here." It can be sort of cliché



because people hear this stuff but when they see or hear about it in the harshest environment on the planet, it becomes very easy for them to go “oh, it works there, so sitting in my Auckland office or Sydney office... it really does apply.”

- I don't want to call it shaming people into moving, but is it sort of like forcing a realisation that this guy has done these amazing things out there, so I can surely do this one thing here?

Yeah in its own form. Some of the times we don't realise the challenge of business that people go through and just how stressful that is. It's just as challenging as a massive trek across the wilderness. People feel that isolation in business, they feel that pressure. And the pressure to be a good wife and businesswoman, or a good dad and manage a team... Taking care of multiple staff or multiple businesses – well its why people top themselves. They feel isolated, like they're alone in the Antarctic wilderness and it can all become too much.

This is why we have our expeditions - because they simulate the harsh environments but they are protected and the people learn how to manage themselves in a difficult challenge in a polar environment or a desert environment, and they can take their knowledge back to their normal world. It teaches them how to manage extreme environments and extreme stress, and keep it in order. The stresses of running a big office or a busy organisation then becomes easier to minimise and organise. It's so valuable.

- I'd imagine going off on an Arctic simulation would give you skills that mean coming back to and dealing with the stresses of the office is like second nature. Like you come back and think “oh yeah, I can do this! Easy!”

Yeah! It can be done in a very short time – an 8 day polar survival course shows them how to Nordic ski, how to use wind power safely and use kites to get from A to B and drag



IN PERSPECTIVE

- Temperatures down to -35 Celsius (-47 with the windchill)

- 90 days of isolation punctuated with only by daily phone call to his wife back in the Gold Coast

- He first trekked 3428 kilometres from northern Antarctica to the west via the south pole pulling his famous “boob sled” between October 2013 and January 2014, raising \$250,000 for breast cancer charity the McGrath Foundation.

- The next trip has plans to travel 5000 kilometres from north to south, starting in November 2016 and finishing in February 2017.

their possessions. It's so good to get man and woman into a position where they feel comfortable in what they had previously seen as a hostile environment and coming away feeling like Bear Grylls. They can think “I have the ability to press on and deal with stress in any business aisle.” The thing about business is you're just not aware of the pressure they're under. So teaching people how to manage those stresses in a simulated environment is so valuable.

We're kind of the crash test dummies for hostile environments and it's incredibly applicable to business. It's phenomenal just how well it teaches people how to deal with stress and how to prevail.

- That's awesome. Finally, you're a huge inspiration to a lot of people nationally and internationally. Have you got any words of wisdom for the masses?

Yeah, don't take it too seriously! At the end of the day, we aren't here for a long time so it doesn't pay to take it too seriously. A lot of the stuff we talk about with drive and motivation IS about taking it seriously and setting goals but it can be just as unhealthy to be completely obsessed with an outcome. I go back to thousands of interviews I've had with people that had lost everything in the Aceh disaster. When I was interviewing, there were bodies all over the street, there were dogs eating babies, it was beyond what a human being should see. Over 200,000 deaths in one city, it doesn't get more gruesome than that. But at the end of the day, no one gave a damn about stuff. It was all about friends and family. So while it's good to drive hard and set great goals, final note is don't take it too seriously and remember your family and friends.